Vajpayee's prestige was seriously dented by his concession though he shared blame with his cabinet. During both Kargil and Kandahar, while Vajpayee discussed the issues with this entire cabinet, the decision at the end of the day was his alone. His NSA, Mishra, was most likely the only other person involved in the difficult choices. Due to the omnipresence of Mishra and Vajpayee's implicit trust in him, the role of the foreign minister had already become limited to those areas where the PMO was simply not interested.

The situation changed considerably when well-known economist Manmohan Singh became prime minister. As a former civil servant Manmohan Singh was known for following rules and he had experienced a cabinet position while serving as Rao's finance minister. Unlike other prime ministers, Manmohan Singh did not hold office in his own right but rather as a nominee of Congress president Sonia Gandhi. During his ten years as prime minister, real power lay not in his PMO but in the office of the president of the Congress party. The prime minister had his own outlook on world affairs. He sought better ties with India's neighbours, including Pakistan, as well as with the United States. The limitations of his authority coupled with the demands of coalition politics severely limited Manmohan Singh's ability to drive the agenda of the government he headed.

Manmohan Singh's close advisers recall that during his tenure the Cabinet Committee on Security (CCS) met every week but the prime minister rarely spoke or intervened during its proceedings. Instead of the CCS, key decisions were discussed in the weekly meeting of the Congress party's core group comprising Sonia Gandhi, Manmohan Singh, Defence Minister A.K. Antony, Finance Minister P. Chidambaram and close Gandhi loyalist Ahmed Patel. While the CCS met on Thursdays, it was the Core Committee's meeting every Friday that acted as the policymaking body. The National Advisory Council (NAC) headed by Sonia Gandhi was